Where the World's Music Comes From

The birthplaces of 291,579 musicians and the home towns of bands in Wikidata, by city, genre, decade and gender

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Abstract

Where are musicians born, and where do bands begin? I use Wikidata, the open knowledge base behind Wikipedia, to map everyone it records with an occupation that is musician or any of its subclasses (478,552 people) and every musical group (115,219). 291,579 musicians (61%) have a birth country and 283,424 a birthplace with coordinates; 29,489 groups have a place of formation with coordinates. Grouping places into city areas, New York (6,124 musicians), London (4,627), Paris (4,466) and Vienna (4,102) lead for births, and Los Angeles (1,454), New York and London for bands. Composers born before 1900 were 88% European, pop, rock and metal musicians born since 1940 only 48%. Many genres have a clear home town: Kingston holds 23% of reggae acts, Seoul 52% of K-pop acts, Rio de Janeiro 57% of samba acts, and Nashville's acts are 13.0 times as likely as the world's to be country. Finland has 84.8 metal bands per million people. Women are 25.4% of musicians with a recorded gender, rising from 8.1% of those born before 1800 to 41.9% of those born in the 1990s, with large differences by kind of musician. Coverage is very uneven: a birth country is recorded for 99.8% of notable musicians but 46% of those with at most one sitelink, and a formation place for 27% of groups. The atlas maps the open record of music, not every musician.

Keywords: musicians; bands; music geography; music scenes; genres; gender; Wikidata; open data; mapping

1 Introduction

Music has always had places. Histories of Western art music are organised around courts, churches and conservatories in a handful of central European cities; histories of popular music around scenes, from New Orleans and Memphis to Liverpool, Kingston, Seattle and Seoul (Connell and Gibson, 2003; Bennett and Peterson, 2004). Geographers have long mapped where musicians come from, starting with the birthplaces of American country and rock musicians (Carney, 1974). A simple question cuts across these traditions: where were the world's musicians born, and where did its bands form?

Wikidata (Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014) offers a way to ask it at a scale no single history can. It records hundreds of thousands of people with musical occupations, many with a place and date of birth, and more than a hundred thousand musical groups, some with a place and date of formation, and it links both to genres. Studies of notable people's birth and death places have shown how much structure such data hold, and how much they reflect the biases of their sources (Schich et al., 2014). This paper maps musicians' birthplaces and bands' formation places by city, country, kind of musician, genre and decade, measures where each genre is concentrated, and tracks the share of women. It pairs the analysis with an interactive atlas (https://maps.tristanhotham.com/music-birthplaces/).

Table 1: From query to data.

Step	Count
Rows returned by the musician query	818,669
Musicians	478,552
with a birthplace	292,146
with a birth country	291,579
with a birthplace point (on the map)	283,424
of which in a city area	181,847
with a year of birth	384,245
with a recorded gender	458,411
with a genre	110,334
notable (20+ sitelinks)	10,946
Musical groups	115,219
with a country	90,469
with a formation place	31,190
with a formation point (on the map)	29,489
with a year of formation	44,057
with a genre	65,023

The contribution is descriptive. Wikidata is not a census of musicians. Its coverage depends on which library catalogues and music databases have been imported and which people have Wikipedia articles, and its records of gender follow those of Wikipedia, where women are known to be under-represented (Wagner et al., 2016). I report coverage alongside every result.

2 Data

Musicians. A query through the QLever SPARQL endpoint (Bast and Buchhold, 2017), retrieved in 2026, returned every human (P31 Q5) with an occupation (P106) that is musician (Q639669) or a subclass of it, with English label, occupation, place of birth (P19), that place's English label, coordinates (P625) and country (P17), date of birth (P569), sex or gender (P21) and number of sitelinks. The export was paged to avoid a time-out; it has 818,669 rows (one per combination of values) for 478,552 people, the same number as a separate count of the set. Six lines lacked a line break and were repaired. 534 occupations appear, from composer, singer and pianist to organist, rapper, kobzar and bertsolari. 63,026 people have no English label.

Groups. A second query returned every item that is an instance of musical group (Q215380) or a subclass, with type, location of formation (P740) and its coordinates and country, inception (P571), dissolution (P576), country of origin (P495) and sitelinks: 118,971 rows for 115,219 groups. Groups include rock bands, idol groups and duos, and also 4,273 choirs, orchestras and ensembles, identified from their type labels.

Genres. Two further queries returned the genres (P136) of musicians and groups and the English labels of the 3,743 genres used.

Geography. Natural Earth (Natural Earth, 2026) countries (1:10m for assigning points, 1:50m for display), land and populated places, with population estimates. All Wikidata content is CC0 and Natural Earth is public domain.

3 Methods

3.1 Places and countries

A musician's birthplace is the first place of birth in the result (2,848 have more than one) and its point is that place's coordinates. 6,968 birthplaces are themselves countries or former states (for example 'Austrian Empire'); these give a country but no point. The birth country is the present-day Natural Earth country that the point falls in, else the place's Wikidata country matched to Natural Earth by Wikidata identifier, with a hand-made table of successors for former states. Where both are known they agree for 99% of musicians. A group's place is its location of formation, and its country that of the place, else its country of origin.

3.2 City areas and per-head rates

Wikidata often records a district (Brooklyn, Hollywood, a Paris arrondissement) rather than a city. I assign each point to the nearest Natural Earth populated place of 200,000 people or more within 25 km, merging any such place within 25 km of a larger one, so that Liverpool and Manchester stay apart but Brooklyn counts with New York. 64% of musicians' points fall in one of 1,725 city areas. Per-head rates divide by Natural Earth's present-day population: a rough guide, since most of these musicians were born when cities were smaller and in different proportion to each other.

3.3 Kinds of musician and genre families

I grouped the occupations into eight families (composers and arrangers, singers, instrumentalists, rappers and MCs, DJs and producers, conductors and bandleaders, songwriters, and other musicians, mostly the generic 'musician') and the genres into thirteen families plus 'other' (classical and opera; rock and punk; metal; pop; K-pop, J-pop and East Asian pop; hip hop; R&B, soul, blues and gospel; jazz; electronic and dance; country; Latin; reggae, Caribbean and African popular; folk and traditional), using ordered rules on English labels checked against the most-used values. Both mappings are published with the data. A person or group belongs to every family of any of its occupations or genres; 160,553 people are in more than one occupation family. Genre shares are among genre-tagged acts only (23% of musicians and 56% of groups have a genre).

3.4 Home towns of genres

For each of 34 named genres I count the acts (musicians born and groups formed) in each city area and report the city with most and its share of all such acts with a point. For the genre families I also compute a location quotient: a family's share of a city's genre-tagged acts divided by its share of all genre-tagged acts, for cities with 25 or more acts in the family and 40 or more tagged acts.

3.5 Decades, gender and notability

Musicians are placed in the decade of their birth (earliest valid year of P569, 800 to 2020; before 1800 pooled) and groups in the decade of their formation. Women and trans women are counted as women and men and trans men as men; 685 musicians have another gender recorded. Shares are among musicians with a recorded gender (96%). Notable musicians and groups are those

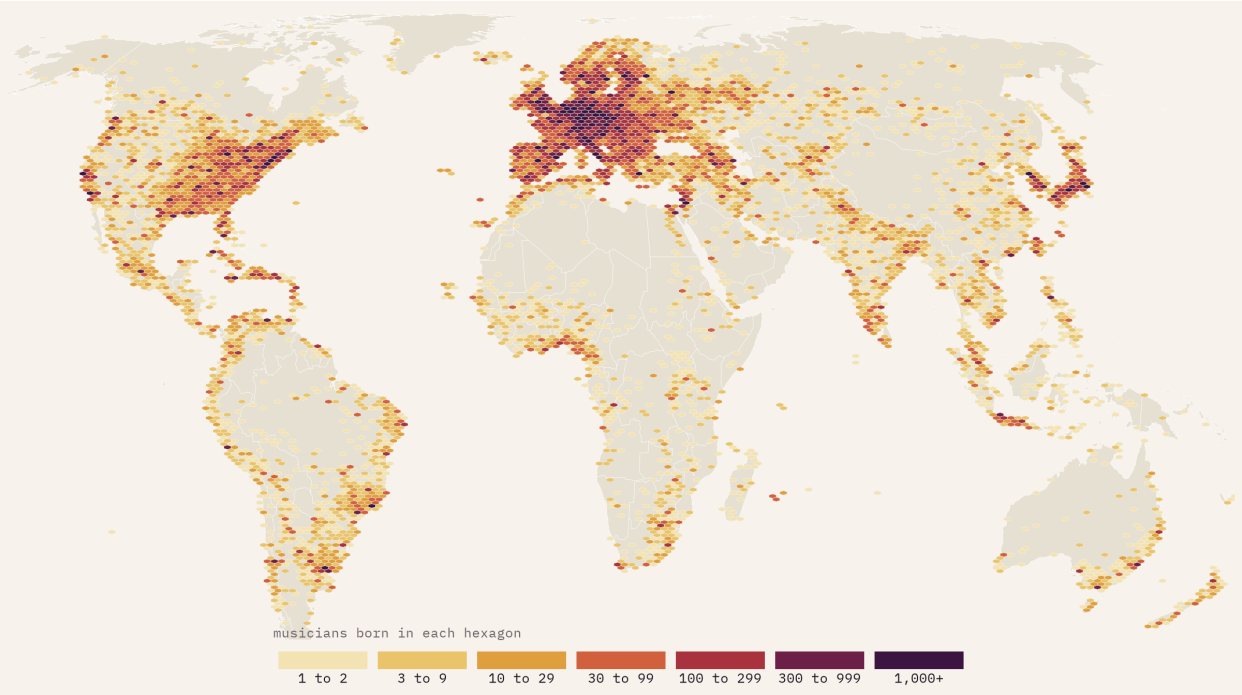


Figure 1: Birthplaces of 283,424 musicians in Wikidata, counted in hexagons (Equal Earth projection).

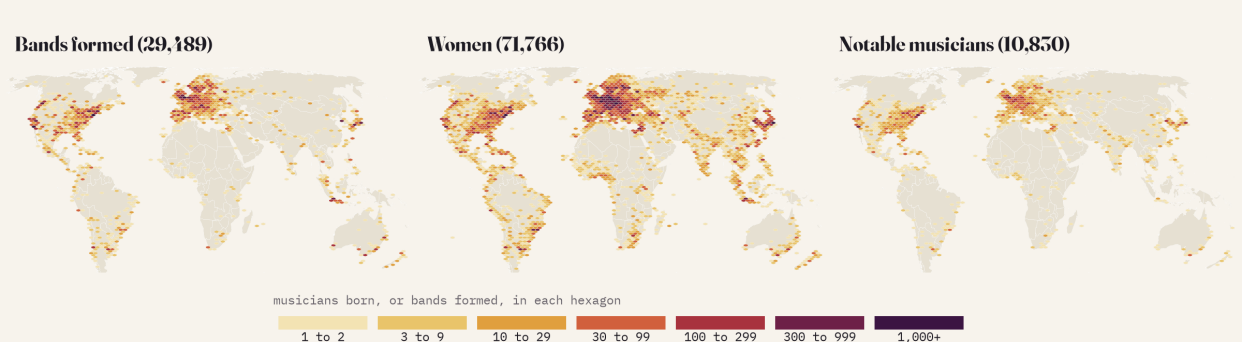


Figure 2: Where bands formed (left), where women musicians were born (centre) and where notable musicians, with 20 or more sitelinks, were born (right).

with 20 or more sitelinks (10,946 musicians, 1,948 groups), a measure of attention on Wikipedia and its sister projects, not of musical standing.

4 Results

4.1 The map

Figure 1 shows all 283,424 birthplace points in hexagons. They are densest in central and western Europe, the eastern United States, Japan and Korea, and sparse across Africa and Central Asia. Europe accounts for 60% of musicians with a birth country, North America 18%, Asia 14%, South America 5.0%, Africa 2.6% and Oceania 0.9%. The maps of bands, of women and of notable musicians (Figure 2) differ in instructive ways: bands are concentrated in North America, western Europe and Japan, and notable musicians in the United States and Britain.

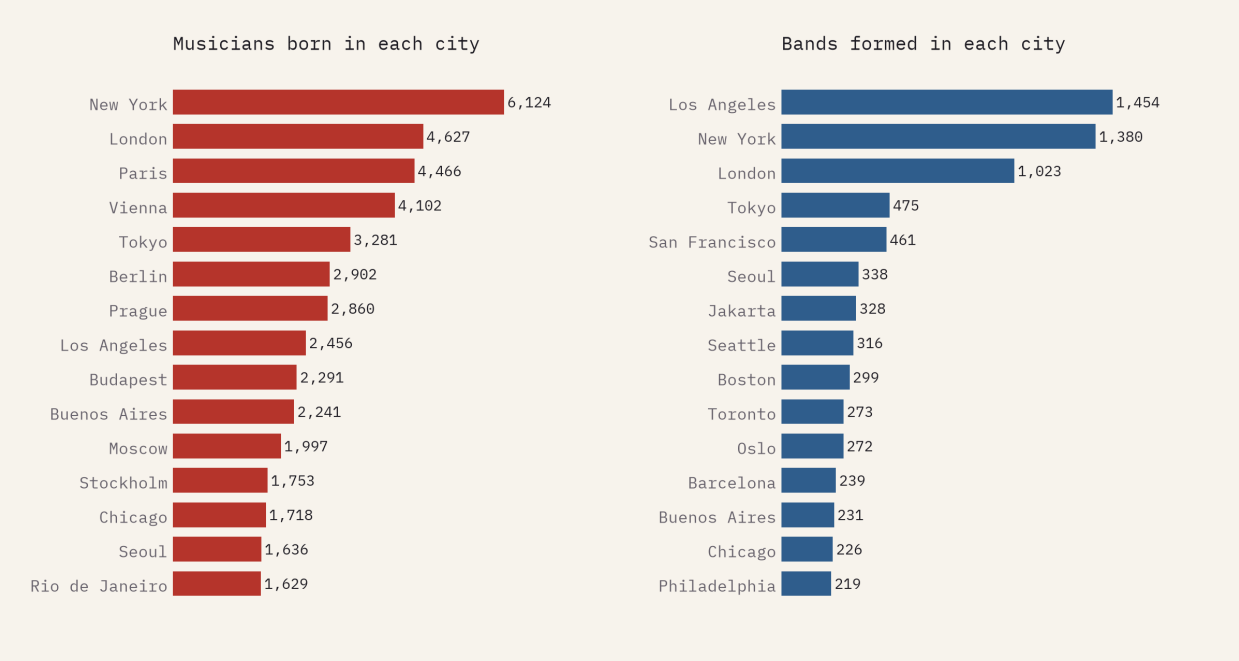


Figure 3: City areas (points within 25 km of a city of 200,000 or more) with most musicians born and most bands formed.

Table 2: City areas: most musicians born (with notable musicians), most musicians per 100,000 present-day residents (cities with 150+ musicians), and most bands formed.

City	Musicians	Notable	City	Per 100,000	City	Bands
New York	6,124	636	Tallinn	253.5	Los Angeles	1,454
London	4,627	426	Prague	246.1	New York	1,380
Paris	4,466	227	Brno	244.7	London	1,023
Vienna	4,102	83	Erfurt	234.7	Tokyo	475
Tokyo	3,281	81	Trieste	180.5	San Francisco	461
Berlin	2,902	74	San Sebastián	177.6	Seoul	338
Prague	2,860	40	Ljubljana	175.0	Jakarta	328
Los Angeles	2,456	320	Vienna	170.9	Seattle	316
Budapest	2,291	43	Graz	167.9	Boston	299
Buenos Aires	2,241	37	Salzburg	164.8	Toronto	273
Moscow	1,997	81	Dresden	152.9	Oslo	272
Stockholm	1,753	70	Amsterdam	148.3	Barcelona	239
Chicago	1,718	135	Leipzig	142.1	Buenos Aires	231
Seoul	1,636	152	Pisa	140.2	Chicago	226
Rio de Janeiro	1,629	31	Bergen	139.5	Philadelphia	219

4.2 Cities

As a single Wikidata place, Vienna is the most common birthplace (3,784), ahead of New York City (2,948) and London (2,792). Grouped into city areas (Figure 3, Table 2), New York leads with 6,124 musicians, then London, Paris, Vienna, Tokyo, Berlin and Prague; the ten largest areas hold 12% of all points. Per head of present population, the leaders are smaller central European cities, Tallinn, Prague, Brno and Erfurt, with more than 230 musicians per 100,000 residents; among cities of a million or more, Prague (246.1) and Vienna (170.9) lead, against New York's 32.2 and Tokyo's 9.2. Bands have a different geography: Los Angeles has most (1,454), then New York, London, Tokyo and San Francisco, and per head Ljubljana, Bergen, Malmö and Oslo.

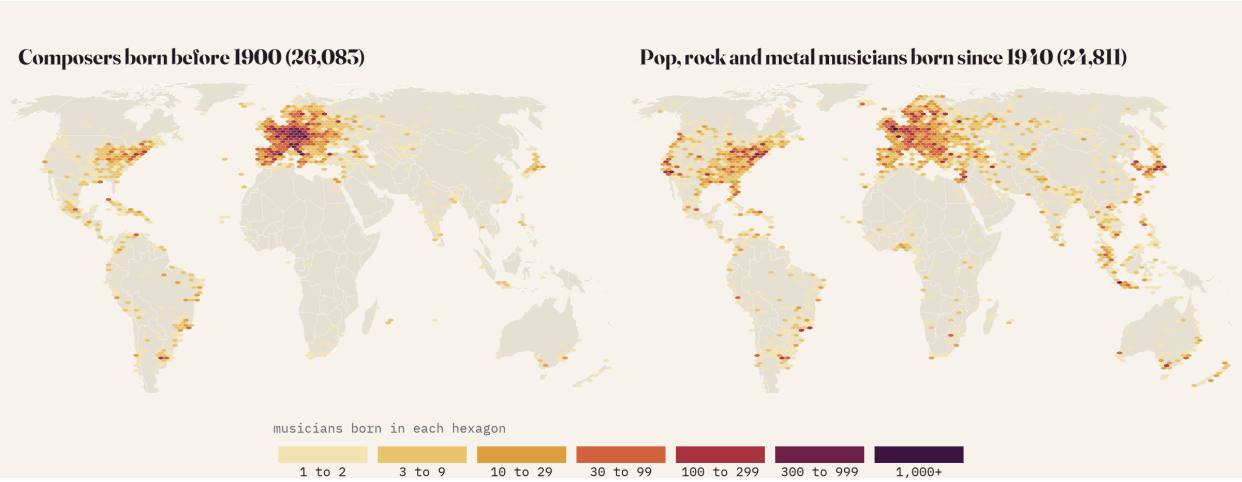


Figure 4: Birthplaces of composers born before 1900 and of pop, rock and metal musicians born in 1940 or later.

Table 3: Kinds of musician: people in each family (a person can be in several), women's share, and continent of birth.

Family	People	Women	Europe	N. America	Asia	S. America	Africa
Composers and arrangers	138,377	12.0%	65.5%	16.2%	9.6%	6.6%	1.4%
Singers	162,850	45.7%	51.7%	18.1%	20.2%	5.1%	3.7%
Instrumentalists	117,378	16.8%	66.8%	19.9%	7.4%	4.2%	1.0%
Rappers and MCs	12,235	11.1%	36.9%	38.3%	12.7%	3.4%	8.2%
DJs and producers	27,484	9.4%	46.0%	31.8%	13.3%	4.1%	3.6%
Conductors and bandleaders	35,075	7.2%	80.0%	11.7%	4.6%	2.7%	0.6%
Songwriters	50,384	27.2%	38.7%	37.5%	14.0%	3.5%	4.6%
Other musicians	170,393	19.6%	62.0%	22.4%	8.1%	4.2%	2.4%

4.3 Composers' Europe and the popular music world

The kinds of musician have different maps (Table 3). Conductors and bandleaders (80% European), instrumentalists and composers are overwhelmingly European; rappers (38% North American) and songwriters are as often North American as European, and singers are the most Asian family (20%). Composers born before 1900 (26,083 with a point) were 87.7% European, led by Vienna (850), Paris (829), London, Prague, Berlin, Naples and Barcelona; pop, rock and metal musicians born in 1940 or later (24,811) were 48.4% European and 27.0% North American, led by London, New York and Los Angeles (Figure 4).

4.4 The home towns of genres

Most genres are spread across many cities, but several have a clear centre (Figure 5, Table 4). Cantopop is concentrated in Hong Kong (74% of its acts), samba in Rio de Janeiro (57%), grime in London (56%), tango in Buenos Aires (52%), K-pop in Seoul (52%) and fado in Lisbon (49%); reggae and dancehall in Kingston, Afrobeats in Lagos, grunge in Seattle and black metal in Oslo, with Bergen second. Country music is the exception that proves the measure: its acts are spread across the United States, so Nashville holds only 4.8% of them, yet Nashville's own acts are 13.0 times as likely as the world's to be country. By the location quotient, reggae and its relatives are most concentrated in Kingston (35.4), jazz in New Orleans (4.5), hip hop in Atlanta (4.8) and soul and R&B in Lagos and Detroit.

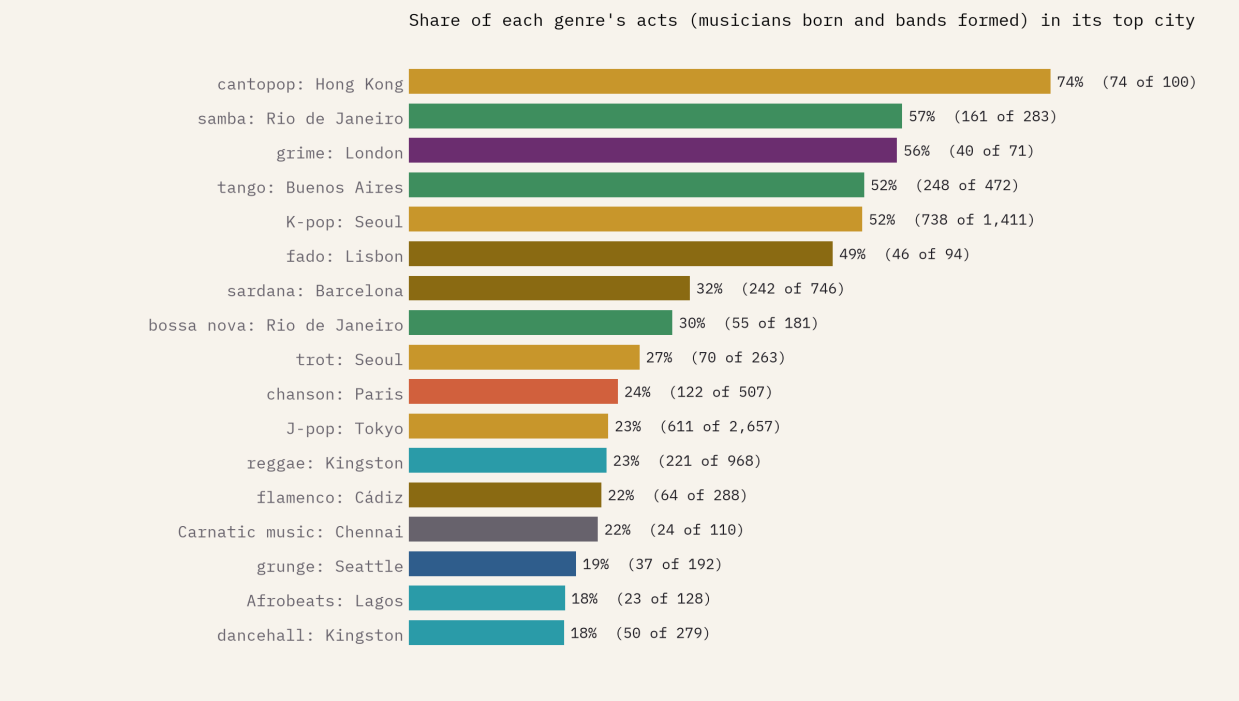


Figure 5: Share of each genre's acts (musicians born and groups formed, with a point) in the city area with most of them. Genres with 20 or more acts in that city.

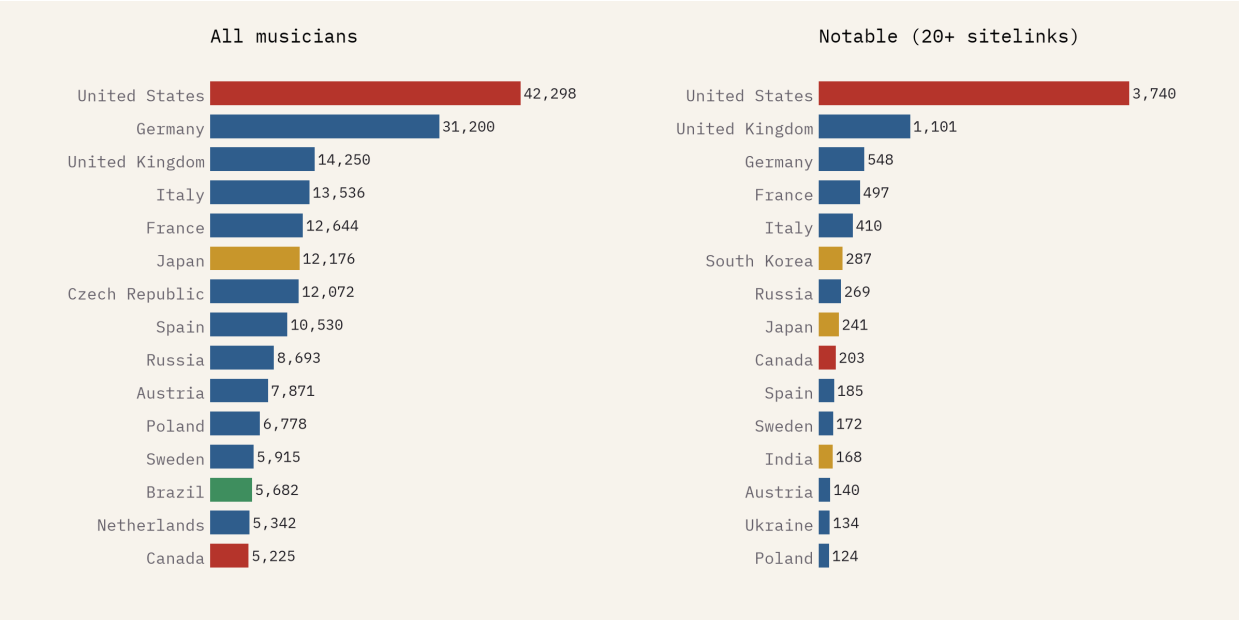


Figure 6: Musicians by country of birth: all with a birth country, and notable musicians. Colours: continent.

4.5 Countries and bands per head

The United States is the birth country of 42,298 musicians (14%), then Germany (31,200), the United Kingdom, Italy, France, Japan and the Czech Republic (Figure 6). Among notable musicians the United States accounts for 34% and the United Kingdom is second. Per head the Czech Republic (1,131 per million), Austria and Estonia stand out, which is in large part a sign of systematic import of national library records. For bands, the Nordic countries lead per head (Figure 7): Finland has 553.8 bands in Wikidata per million people, Norway 376.4 and Sweden 266.2, and for metal bands 84.8, 55.5 and 56.2, against 12.3 in Germany and 6.7 in the United States.

Table 4: Home towns of named genres: the city area with most acts (musicians born and groups formed) tagged with the genre, the number of such acts on the map, the city's share, and the runner-up.

Genre	City	Acts	Of	Share	Next	Acts
cantopop	Hong Kong	74	100	74.0%	Shanghai	3
samba	Rio de Janeiro	161	283	56.9%	São Paulo	25
grime	London	40	71	56.3%	Birmingham	4
tango	Buenos Aires	248	472	52.5%	Montevideo	27
K-pop	Seoul	738	1,411	52.3%	Busan	77
fado	Lisbon	46	94	48.9%	Porto	8
sardana	Barcelona	242	746	32.4%	Valencia	7
bossa nova	Rio de Janeiro	55	181	30.4%	São Paulo	14
trot	Seoul	70	263	26.6%	Busan	26
chanson	Paris	122	507	24.1%	Moscow	16
J-pop	Tokyo	611	2,657	23.0%	Ōsaka	262
reggae	Kingston	221	968	22.8%	London	27
flamenco	Cádiz	64	288	22.2%	Seville	29
Carnatic music	Chennai	24	110	21.8%	Mumbai	5
grunge	Seattle	37	192	19.3%	Los Angeles	8
Afrobeats	Lagos	23	128	18.0%	Port Harcourt	4
dancehall	Kingston	50	279	17.9%	London	9
reggaeton	San Juan	73	412	17.7%	Lima	26
salsa	New York	30	179	16.8%	Lima	27
highlife	Accra	7	49	14.3%	Lagos	6
sertanejo	São Paulo	13	106	12.3%	Goiânia	8
Britpop	London	11	92	12.0%	Liverpool	7
house music	New York	63	707	8.9%	Chicago	47
black metal	Oslo	38	500	7.6%	Bergen	20
jazz	New York	808	11,580	7.0%	Chicago	278
schlager	Berlin	31	462	6.7%	Helsinki	16
techno	London	20	348	5.7%	Detroit	17
heavy metal	Los Angeles	82	1,593	5.1%	New York	59
country music	Nashville	118	2,463	4.8%	New York	50
trap music	New York	33	681	4.8%	Atlanta	30
blues	New York	60	1,535	3.9%	Chicago	54
death metal	Stockholm	21	588	3.6%	Tampa	18
opera	Paris	169	5,045	3.3%	Naples	88
bluegrass	Toronto	8	241	3.3%	Los Angeles	8

4.6 The shift by decade of birth

Figure 8 shows musicians' continents of birth by decade. Of those born before 1900, 87.2% were born in Europe and 2.3% in Asia; of those born since 1970, 49.1% and 22.7%. Germany falls from 18.6% to 8.2%, Italy from 9.3% to 3.0%, while the United States rises from 6.3% to 14.3%, Japan from 0.3% to 6.1% and South Korea from almost nothing to 3.4% (Figure 9). Groups are young: 96% of those with a known start were formed in 1960 or later, most in the 2000s.

4.7 Women

Women are 25.4% of musicians with a recorded gender and 35.4% of notable ones. By decade of birth (Figure 10, Table 5) the share rises from 8.1% before 1800 to about a fifth through the nineteenth century, stays near a fifth for musicians born between 1900 and the 1950s, and then rises to 26.4% for the 1970s, 36.8% for the 1980s and 41.9% for the 1990s. The kind of musician matters more than the decade: women are 45.7% of singers, 27.2% of songwriters, 16.8% of instrumental-

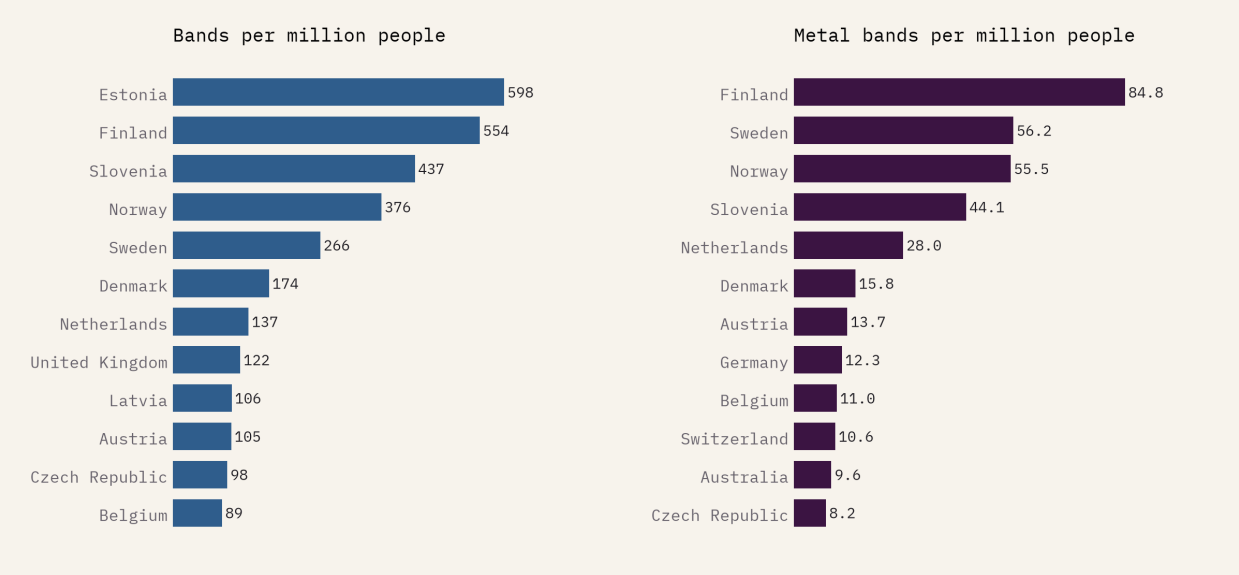


Figure 7: Bands and metal bands per million present-day population, countries of a million or more with 100+ bands (30+ metal bands).

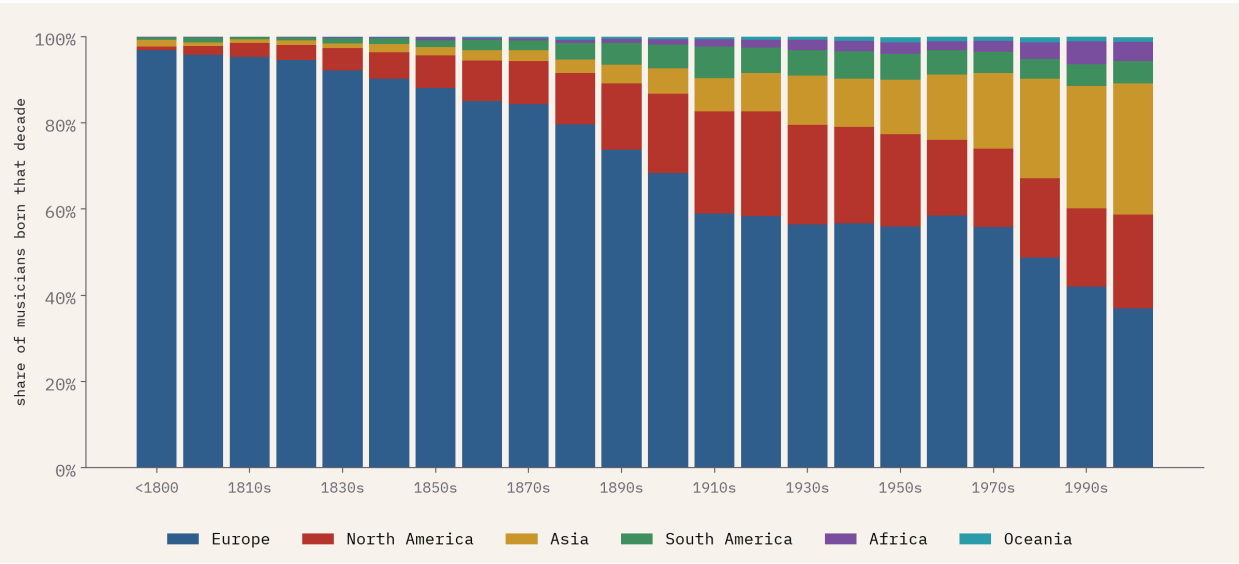


Figure 8: Continent of birth of musicians, by decade of birth (before 1800 pooled).

ists, 12.0% of composers, 11.1% of rappers, 9.4% of DJs and producers and 7.2% of conductors. Among genre families, East Asian pop has a majority of women (53.8%) and metal the smallest share (9.0%). By birth country, the highest shares are for musicians born in Indonesia, China, South Korea and Japan, all above 40%, and among the lowest for Germany, the Czech Republic and Italy, where catalogues of classical musicians weigh heavily.

4.8 Coverage

Birthplace coverage is the main limitation (Figure 11). Notable musicians almost always have a birth country (99.8%); the 61% of musicians with at most one sitelink only 46%. Musicians with no date of birth have a birth country only 12.6% of the time. For groups, a formation place with coordinates is recorded for 25.6% overall, 17.7% of those with at most one sitelink and 86.6% of notable ones. Coverage by kind of musician is more even: among the named kinds it ranges from

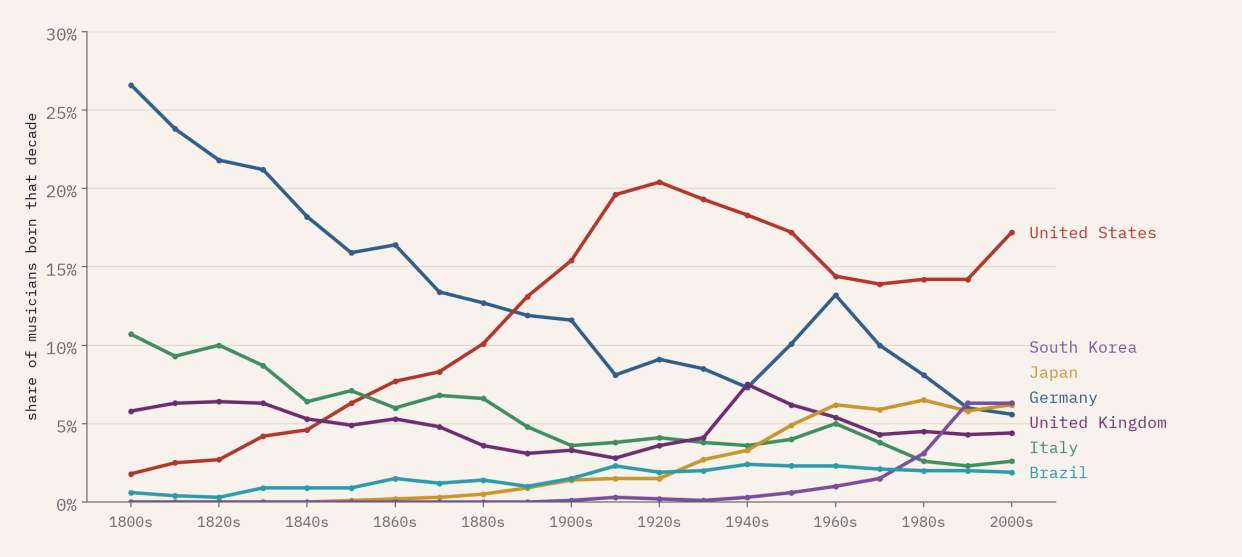


Figure 9: Share of each decade's musicians born in selected countries.

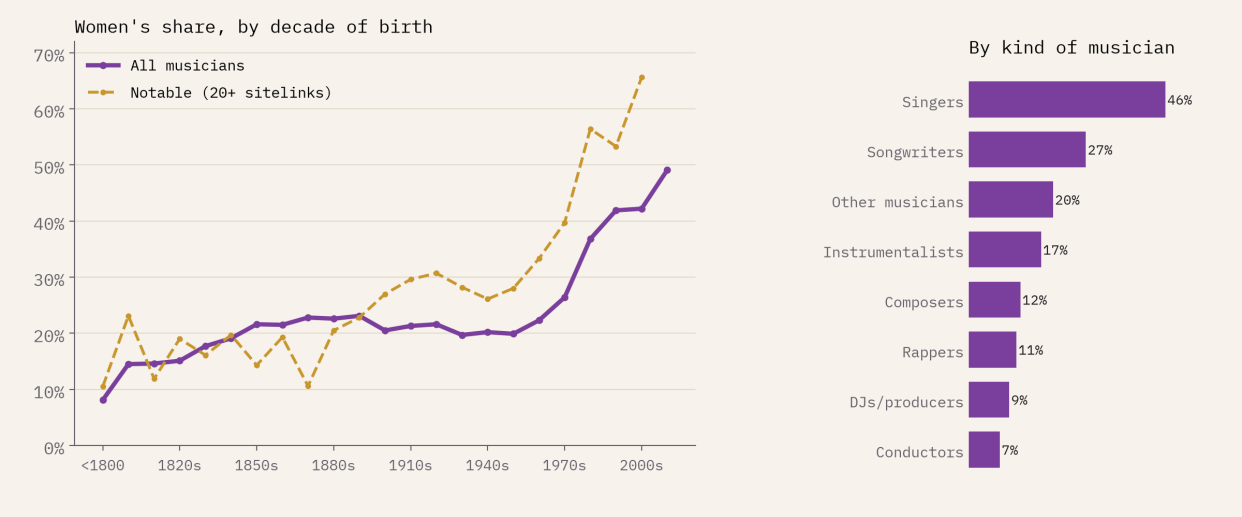


Figure 10: Women's share of musicians by decade of birth, for all and notable musicians, and by kind of musician.

61.7% of DJs and producers to 75.2% of conductors.

5 Discussion

The open record reproduces several familiar features of music history: the central European heartland of art music, with Vienna, Paris, Prague and Berlin; the Anglo-American centre of popular music in London, New York and Los Angeles; the rise of Japanese and Korean popular music; and the strong identity of scenes such as Nashville, Kingston, Rio de Janeiro, Buenos Aires, Seattle and Oslo, which the location quotient picks out with no prior knowledge. It also makes visible things that national histories rarely show side by side, such as how much more European conductors are than rappers, or how much more Nordic the band map is than the map of musicians.

Every one of these findings is shaped by coverage. A country's number of musicians in Wikidata depends on whether its national library or music databases have been imported, and whether the import included birthplaces; Tallinn's, Prague's and Brno's high per-head rates are in large

Table 5: By decade of birth: musicians with a recorded gender, women, women's share among all and among notable musicians (where 30 or more), and the share of all musicians with a birth country.

Born	With gender	Women	Share	Notable	Share	Birth country known
before 1800	16,930	1,367	8.1%	618	10.5%	68%
1800s	2,223	323	14.5%	39	23.1%	73%
1810s	2,639	386	14.6%	59	11.9%	75%
1820s	2,940	443	15.1%	42	19.0%	76%
1830s	3,186	563	17.7%	56	16.1%	78%
1840s	3,846	733	19.1%	61	19.7%	78%
1850s	4,870	1,051	21.6%	56	14.3%	75%
1860s	5,994	1,289	21.5%	88	19.3%	77%
1870s	7,476	1,702	22.8%	113	10.6%	77%
1880s	8,842	1,995	22.6%	161	20.5%	77%
1890s	10,153	2,349	23.1%	228	22.8%	77%
1900s	15,090	3,090	20.5%	256	27.0%	73%
1910s	13,898	2,957	21.3%	358	29.6%	76%
1920s	19,228	4,154	21.6%	592	30.7%	78%
1930s	22,659	4,454	19.7%	717	28.2%	76%
1940s	31,611	6,393	20.2%	1,142	26.1%	75%
1950s	39,959	7,958	19.9%	970	28.0%	71%
1960s	42,834	9,573	22.3%	1,170	33.3%	70%
1970s	46,155	12,169	26.4%	1,380	39.7%	71%
1980s	41,610	15,307	36.8%	1,549	56.4%	72%
1990s	25,044	10,489	41.9%	1,068	53.3%	73%
2000s	9,632	4,060	42.2%	186	65.6%	62%
2010s	336	165	49.1%	1	n/a	62%

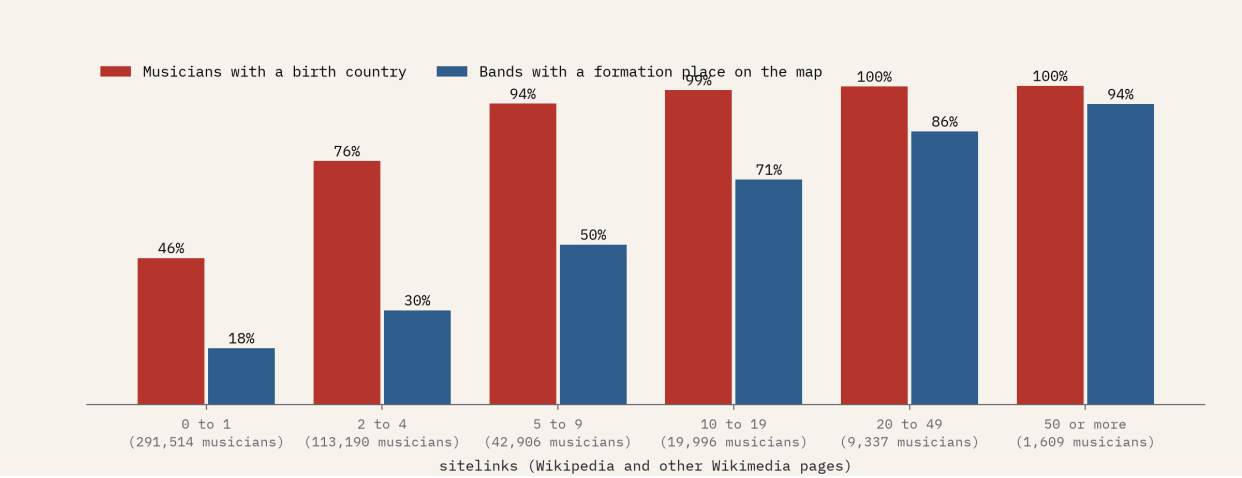


Figure 11: Share of musicians with a birth country, and of groups with a formation place on the map, by number of sitelinks.

part facts about the record. Bands have formation places much less often than musicians have birthplaces, and genre tags are present for a minority of musicians. The safest comparisons are relative ones within the data, such as women's share by kind of musician, or a city's share of a genre's acts.

6 Limitations

First, Wikidata is incomplete and uneven: 61% of musicians have a birth country and 27% of groups a formation place. Second, the population is defined by Wikidata's occupation classes, which are generous: the most linked 'musicians' include Leonardo da Vinci, Goethe, Martin Luther and Nietzsche, who did play or compose. Third, birth countries use present-day borders. Fourth, families of occupations and genres come from rules on English labels; a few assignments are debatable, and the lists are published so readers can regroup them. Fifth, gender is as recorded, mostly binary, and missing for 4% of musicians. Sixth, city areas use a fixed 25 km radius and present-day populations. Finally, all counts are for one retrieval in 2026.

7 Conclusion

A few open queries are enough to map where nearly half a million musicians were born and where tens of thousands of bands formed, to show how that geography moved from central Europe towards North America and East Asia, to find the home towns of genres, and to measure how unevenly women appear across kinds of musician. The same data show clearly where the record is thin. The atlas lets readers explore both.

Data and code availability

The interactive atlas is at https://maps.tristanhotham.com/music-birthplaces/. Data and code are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/music-birthplaces and archived with this paper at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23850287. Derived data are released under CC BY 4.0 and code under the MIT licence.

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

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